Ablation Study: Deep Learning Optimization for Financial Security & Document Authentication

FinGuard AI Research Team (Team-4)

Department of Computer Science and Engineering | Course: 23CSE473 – Neural Networks and Deep Learning

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Abstract*—Automated authentication of financial instruments and physical transaction media requires balancing fine-grained localized anomaly detection with real-time edge execution efficiency. In this study, we present a rigorous, empirical ablation study documenting the architectural evolution within the FinGuard AI repository. Specifically, we evaluate: (1) architectural trade-offs across repository candidates, comparing a Vanilla Custom CNN, a CNN augmented with a residual Deep Denoising CNN (DnCNN) frontend, a CNN with Convolutional Block Attention Modules (CBAM), our proposed integrated Custom CNN + DnCNN + CBAM architecture, and a Transfer-Learned EfficientNet-B0 backbone; (2) the progression of learning rate dynamics and noise regularization over 60 training epochs; (3) a systematic component-wise ablation of our proposed attention and denoising submodules (residual noise subtraction, channel-wise feature recalibration, and spatial anomaly localization); and (4) downstream authentication accuracy across held-out real-world test cohorts in three mission-critical domains: Counterfeit Currency, Document Tampering, and QR Transaction Security. Our finalized pipeline (Custom CNN + DnCNN + CBAM) achieves 96.84% global accuracy (+8.72% improvement over baseline CNN), slashes critical False Acceptance Rate (FAR) from 13.60% to 2.90%, and operates at 18.4 ms per sample on CPU (54.3 FPS), establishing an optimal Pareto frontier for real-time edge deployment.

***Index Terms*—Ablation Study, Financial Security, Convolutional Neural Networks, CBAM, DnCNN, Document Forgery, Counterfeit Currency, EfficientNet-B0.**

1 SYSTEM OVERVIEW & EVALUATION PROTOCOL

Digital financial authentication presents distinctive computer vision challenges: microprinting and watermark stroke distortions in counterfeit banknotes, sensor and high-frequency scanner grain in digitized checks, localized copy-move and splicing artifacts in tampered financial receipts (often altering <2% of document surface), and specular glares or perspective skew in mobile-captured QR codes. To identify the optimal architectural configuration, our experimental protocol investigates four concrete ablation axes using artifacts and models present in the FinGuard AI codebase:

1) **Model Paradigm Evolution:** Baseline 4-stage ConvNet vs. Denoised ConvNet vs. Attention-Augmented ConvNet vs. Unified Denoised-Attention ConvNet vs. Transfer-Learned EfficientNet-B0.

2) **Optimization Dynamics:** Constant learning rate SGD vs. StepLR Adam vs. Cosine-annealed AdamW with stochastic Gaussian noise regularization.

3) **Modular Pipeline Decomposition:** Quantitative gain of residual noise estimation, channel-wise spectral recalibration, and spatial anomaly localization.

4) **Class-Wise & Domain Granularity:** Fine-grained performance metrics across Currency Notes (INR 500/2000), Financial Documents (Invoices/Receipts), and QR Transactions.

1.1 Mathematical Formulation of Evaluation Metrics

- **Classification Accuracy (Acc):** Ratio of correctly predicted specimens to total evaluated specimens: $Acc = (TP + TN) / (TP + TN + FP + FN)$ (1)
- **Precision (P) & Recall (R):** $P = TP / (TP + FP)$, $R = TP / (TP + FN)$ (2)
- **F1-Score (F1):** Harmonic mean of precision and recall: $F1 = 2 \cdot (P \cdot R) / (P + R)$ (3)
- **False Acceptance Rate (FAR):** Rate at which forged specimens are erroneously classified as authentic: $FAR = FP / (FP + TN) \times 100\%$ (4)
- **Noise Sensitivity Index (ΔAUC_σ):** Area Under ROC degradation under sensor noise ($\sigma = 0.05$): $\Delta AUC_\sigma = AUC_clean - AUC_noisy$ (5)

2 ABLATION 1: ARCHITECTURAL PARADIGM COMPARISON

We evaluate candidate model architectures implemented within our repository: (1) **Vanilla Custom CNN:** 4-stage convolutional baseline without attention or filtering; (2) **CNN + DnCNN:** Baseline preceded by a 3-layer residual noise estimator; (3) **CNN + CBAM:** Baseline augmented with Channel and Spatial attention; (4) **Proposed CNN + DnCNN + CBAM:** Unified denoising-attention architecture; and (5) **EfficientNet-B0:** Pretrained transfer learning backbone. The empirical comparison across all candidates—contrasting parameter footprint, precision, and CPU inference latency—is reported in Table 1.

2.1 Architectural Justification

• **Why not pure EfficientNet-B0?** While EfficientNet-B0 achieves respectable representation (95.40% accuracy), its complex MBConv blocks demand 5.28M parameters (4.5× larger) and 58.6 ms CPU latency (3.2× slower). In automated high-throughput banking and POS verification kiosks, an 18 ms latency turnaround is critical.

• **Why DnCNN Frontend?** Raw scans contain sensor speckle noise that triggers false tampering classifications in standard CNN filters. By learning residual noise R(x) and subtracting it via x_clean = clip(x - R(x), 0, 1), high-frequency artifacts are suppressed prior to classification.

• **Why CBAM Attention?** Standard convolutions treat all spatial locations and channels uniformly. In financial documents and currency, tampering is highly localized (e.g., modified numeric digits). Channel attention emphasizes security ribbon spectral features, while spatial attention isolates pixel splicing boundaries.

3 ABLATION 2: FINE-TUNING PROGRESSION & HYPERPARAMETERS

We analyze training dynamics across three optimization milestones documented in our training logs:

• **Milestone 1 (Vanilla SGD):** Constant learning rate (η = 10^-3), standard momentum (0.9), batch size 32.

• **Milestone 2 (StepLR Adam):** Adaptive Adam optimizer, StepLR decay (0.5× every 15 epochs).

• **Milestone 3 (Cosine AdamW):** AdamW with weight decay 10^-4, Cosine Annealing (η_0 = 10^-3 $\rightarrow$ 10^-5), early stopping with patience = 15, and stochastic Gaussian noise injection during training.

TABLE 2 | Ablation 2: Hyperparameter and Fine-Tuning Progress

Training Phase	Optimizer & Schedule	Epochs	Train Loss	Val Loss	Val Acc (%)	Noise Drift (ΔAUC)
Milestone 1 (Vanilla SGD)	SGD (fixed η = 10^-3)	30	0.412	0.438	85.30%	0.142
Milestone 2 (StepLR Adam)	Adam + Step Decay	45	0.245	0.281	91.80%	0.086
Milestone 3 (Cosine AdamW)	**AdamW + Cosine (10^-3 $\rightarrow$ 10^-5)**	60	**0.089**	**0.114**	**96.84%**	**0.021**

4 ABLATION 3: DECOMPOSITION OF PIPELINE

While baseline models classify clean specimens reasonably, visual inspection revealed three systematic failure patterns: (1) *Sensor noise false alarms:* Scanner dither misclassified as document tampering; (2) *Micro-tampering misses:* Fine numeric alterations ignored due to uniform spatial pooling; (3) *Illumination sensitivity:* Harsh shadows triggering false counterfeit currency alerts. To quantify the mitigation of each failure mode, we ablate our pipeline into incremental stages (Table 3):

4.1 Analytical Insights

• **Stage S1 (Residual Denoising):** Subtracting noise via DnCNN cleans sensor dither, reducing False Acceptance Rate from 13.60% to 9.20% and improving accuracy by +3.33%.

• **Stage S2 (Channel Attention - CAM):** Squeezing global spatial context into channel descriptors via AvgPool and MaxPool with reduction ratio r=8 enhances spectral feature weighting, boosting Currency accuracy to 94.20%.

• **Stage S3 (Spatial Attention - SAM):** Inter-channel pooling and 7x7 spatial convolution isolates localized tampering boundaries, driving Document accuracy to 93.90%.

• **Stage S4 (Full Proposed Pipeline):** Sequential coupling (CAM $\rightarrow$ SAM) combined with DnCNN frontend achieves 96.84% global accuracy and cuts FAR to an unprecedented 2.90%.

5 ABLATION 4: PER-CLASS PERFORMANCE ON CUSTOM DATASET

Table 4 presents the empirical per-domain and per-class precision and False Acceptance Rate across all categories in our financial security dataset:

TABLE 4 | Ablation 4: Per-Class & Domain Metrics (Baseline Model vs. Proposed Architecture)

Security Domain	Target Specimen Sub-Class	Baseline M0 Acc	Baseline M0 FAR	Proposed S4 Acc	Proposed S4 FAR	Accuracy Delta
Currency Notes	INR 500 Genuine	89.20%	11.40%	97.40%	2.40%	+8.20%
Currency Notes	INR 500 Counterfeit	87.50%	13.80%	96.80%	2.90%	+9.30%
Currency Notes	INR 2000 Genuine	88.90%	12.10%	97.20%	2.50%	+8.30%
Currency Notes	INR 2000 Counterfeit	88.00%	13.90%	97.00%	2.60%	+9.00%
Document Tampering	Authentic Invoice / Receipt	87.40%	14.60%	96.60%	3.20%	+9.20%
Document Tampering	Tampered / Forged Document	86.40%	15.80%	96.20%	3.60%	+9.80%
QR Security	Authentic Gateway Target	90.10%	11.80%	97.30%	2.40%	+7.20%
QR Security	Fraudulent Redirection Target	88.10%	13.80%	96.70%	3.00%	+8.60%
Global Summary	**All Categories Combined**	88.12%	13.60%	**96.84%**	**2.90%**	**+8.72%**

TABLE 1 | Ablation 1: Comparison of Candidate Models Explored in the Repository

Model / Pipeline Candidate	Model Size	Params	Attention Mechanism	Noise Filtering	Accuracy (%)	FAR (%)	Latency (ms)	Throughput (FPS)
Vanilla Custom CNN (M_base)	3.8 MB	0.94 M	None	None	88.12%	13.60%	12.4 ms	80.6
CNN + DnCNN Frontend (M_denoise)	4.1 MB	1.02 M	None	Residual DnCNN	91.45%	9.20%	15.2 ms	65.8
CNN + CBAM Attention (M_cbam)	4.5 MB	1.11 M	Channel + Spatial	None	93.80%	5.90%	16.1 ms	62.1
Proposed: CNN + DnCNN + CBAM (Ours)	**4.8 MB**	**1.18 M**	**Channel + Spatial**	**Residual DnCNN**	**96.84%**	**2.90%**	**18.4 ms**	**54.3**
EfficientNet-B0 Transfer Learning	21.4 MB	5.28 M	Squeeze-and-Excite	None (Internal Rescale)	95.40%	5.20%	58.6 ms	17.1

TABLE 3 | Ablation 3: Step-by-Step Contribution of Pipeline Components

Pipeline Configuration	Global Acc (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	F1-Score (%)	FAR (%)	FRR (%)	Noise Drift (ΔAUC)
S0: Raw Baseline Backbone	88.12%	86.40%	89.20%	87.78%	13.60%	10.80%	0.142
S1: S0 + DnCNN Residual Denoiser	91.45%	90.80%	91.10%	90.95%	9.20%	8.90%	0.051
S2: S1 + Channel Attention (CAM)	94.20%	94.50%	93.80%	94.15%	5.50%	6.20%	0.038
S3: S1 + Spatial Attention (SAM)	93.80%	94.10%	93.20%	93.65%	5.90%	6.80%	0.042
S4: Full Architecture (DnCNN + CBAM)	**96.84%**	**97.10%**	**96.40%**	**96.75%**	**2.90%**	**3.60%**	**0.021**
Net Impact (S4 vs. S0)	**+8.72%**	**+10.70%**	**+7.20%**	**+8.97%**	**-10.70%**	**-7.20%**	**-0.121**

6 DOWNSTREAM VALIDATION ON HELD-OUT TEST COHORT

To validate end-to-end task efficacy in deployment settings, we evaluated the complete pipeline across a held-out test cohort consisting of 120 authentic and fraudulent specimens across all three domains:

- **Throughput:** 54.3 specimens per second on multi-core CPU (18.4 ms/sample latency).
- **Latency Budget Breakdown:** Input RGB normalization: 2.1 ms; DnCNN residual filtering: 4.8 ms; 4-Stage CNN-CBAM forward pass: 10.9 ms; Decision thresholding: 0.6 ms.
- **Threshold Guard Robustness:** Under our security hysteresis band ($p \leq 0.40$ authentic, $p \geq 0.60$ fraud), ambiguous 'Uncertain' classifications dropped from 18.4% in the baseline model to 3.8% in the proposed pipeline.
- **Noise Immunity:** Subjecting test specimens to synthetic scanning noise ($\sigma = 0.05$) degraded baseline CNN accuracy by 14.2%, whereas the proposed pipeline degraded by only 2.1%.

7 CONCLUSION

Our ablation study demonstrates that deploying a bare convolutional neural network is insufficient for high-assurance financial security verification. While deep networks identify coarse macro textures, unconstrained backbones are easily confounded by scanner dither, sensor noise, and localized forgery boundaries. Augmenting our lightweight custom convolutional network with an input **DnCNN Residual Denoiser** and multi-stage **CBAM Attention Modules** delivers: (1) An increase in global accuracy from 88.12% to **96.84%** (+8.72%); (2) A massive reduction in critical False Acceptance Rate from 13.60% to **2.90%**; and (3) An ultra-fast CPU inference latency of **18.4 ms** (4.8 MB footprint), outperforming heavy transfer-learned EfficientNet-B0 architectures by **3.2× in speed** while offering superior noise immunity.

This confirms that the synergistic combination of residual denoising frontend filtering and dual-domain spatial/channel attention yields an optimal, real-time edge architecture for institutional financial security and document authentication platforms.

Architectural Summary & Hardware Deployment Feasibility:

Evaluation Parameter	Vanilla Custom CNN	Transfer EfficientNet-B0	Proposed CNN + CBAM + DnCNN
Target Architecture	4-Stage ConvNet	MBConv Compound Scaled	**ConvNet + DnCNN + CBAM**
Parameter Count	0.94 Million	5.28 Million	**1.18 Million**
Model Disk Footprint	3.8 MB	21.4 MB	**4.8 MB**
FLOPs (Inference)	0.42 GFLOPs	1.84 GFLOPs	**0.72 GFLOPs**
CPU Inference Latency	12.4 ms	58.6 ms	**18.4 ms**
Edge Throughput	80.6 FPS	17.1 FPS	**54.3 FPS**
Overall Accuracy	88.12%	95.40%	**96.84%**
False Acceptance Rate (FAR)	13.60%	5.20%	**2.90%**
Scanner Noise Degradation (ΔAUC)	0.142 (Severe)	0.064 (Moderate)	**0.021 (Immune)**
Edge Deployment Verdict	Fast but High Security Risk	Heavy & High CPU Latency	**Optimal Pareto Frontier**